

What Is Justice? Plato's Republic and the Ideally Ordered City

An original lesson plan inspired by **Plato (trans. Benjamin Jowett)**'s *The Republic* (Archive.org). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Archive.org or Plato (trans. Benjamin Jowett). Explore the original course: <https://archive.org/details/in.ernet.dli.2015.223393>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	65 minutes	Political Philosophy

“Plato has Socrates argue that justice in a person mirrors justice in a city — a harmony among distinct parts each doing their own proper job. Is justice really a kind of internal and social harmony, rather than a matter of following rules or laws?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain the challenge posed to Socrates by Glaucon — that people are only just because they lack the power, like the Ring of Gyges, to get away with injustice.
- Trace Plato's construction of the ideal city with its three classes as an analogy for the three parts of the soul.
- Evaluate Plato's definition of justice as each part of the soul or city performing its proper function in harmony, and identify the theory's strongest weakness.

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Excerpt handout: the Ring of Gyges story (Book II) and the analogy of city and soul (selections from Books II and IV) in the Jowett translation
- Reflection prompt: "What would you do with a ring of invisibility?"
- Diagram handout mapping the three classes of the city against the three parts of the soul

Lesson Procedure

Hook: The Ring of Gyges

10 min

Tell the story of the ring that grants invisibility, found by a shepherd who uses it to seduce the queen, murder the king, and seize the throne. Ask students: if you had this ring and could never be caught, would you still act justly? Take a brief poll and record a few students' reasons.

Direct Instruction: The Challenge and Plato's Strategy

17 min

Present Glaucon's challenge: is justice good only for its consequences, such as reputation or avoiding punishment, or is it good in itself, even for someone who could get away with injustice? Explain that Socrates proposes to find justice 'writ large' in a city first, then apply the same structure to the individual soul, and introduce the city's three classes (producers, guardians/auxiliaries, philosopher-rulers) alongside the soul's three parts (appetite, spirit, reason).

Small-Group Mapping Activity

16 min

In groups, students complete the diagram matching each class of the city to its parallel part of the soul, and articulate Plato's definition of justice: each part doing its own proper job and not meddling in the others', with reason ruling, aided by spirit, over appetite.

Whole-Class Discussion

16 min

Debate whether this definition of justice actually answers Glaucon's challenge about the ring of invisibility. Also raise Plato's reliance on philosopher-kings and the 'noble lie' used to hold the city together, and ask whether this reveals an authoritarian implication in the theory.

Closure

6 min

Return to the opening ring-of-Gyges poll and ask whether Plato's answer changes anyone's reasoning about why they gave their original response.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does Plato's definition of justice, harmony among the parts of the soul or city, actually answer Glaucon's challenge, or does it just relocate the question of why order and harmony are good?
- 2 If you had the Ring of Gyges and could never be caught, do you think you would still act justly? Does your answer support or undermine Plato's claim that justice is good in itself, independent of reputation or punishment?
- 3 Plato's ideal city relies on philosopher-rulers who understand the Form of the Good, and even a 'noble lie' to keep the classes content with their roles. Does this make the Republic a blueprint for a good society, or a warning about the dangers of rule by supposed experts?
- 4 Is the analogy between the just city and the just soul a fair one, or does Plato assume what he needs to prove by designing the city's structure to match his preferred theory of the soul?
- 5 Plato has each class in the city restricted to one social role for life. What does this imply about individual freedom and mobility, and is it a cost Plato is willing to accept for the sake of harmony?

Assessment

Students write a short essay stating whether Plato's definition of justice, harmony among the parts of the soul or city with each performing its proper function, successfully answers Glaucon's challenge from the Ring of Gyges,



using specific claims from the assigned excerpts to support their position.

Extension Activity

Have students design their own diagram or short proposal for an 'ideally just city,' explicitly deciding whether they adopt Plato's three-class structure or reject it, and write a short justification connecting their design back to a definition of justice.

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